

Nabucco for Milanese audiences was the chorus “Va, pensiero,” a stirring lament for the conquered and enslaved Hebrews. It was adopted as a patriotic anthem by Italians resentful of the rule exercised by the Austrian Hapsburgs over northern Italy. Verdi’s next opera, *I Lombardi*, staged in Milan in 1843 to a similarly enthusiastic reception, also had nationalist overtones and, like its predecessors, slipped past the Austrian censors.

“I am the **least erudite** among **past** and **present composers.**”

GIUSEPPE VERDI

Although Verdi was sympathetic to the Italian nationalist cause, he took no part in political plots. After the success of *Ernani*, based on a play by Victor Hugo, his growing international reputation led him to spend long periods abroad and when Italy erupted in revolution in 1848, he was in Paris enjoying a love affair with the soprano Giuseppina Strepponi.

“In the **theater** the **public** will stand for **anything but boredom.**”

GIUSEPPE VERDI, LETTER, 1869

Verdi did, however, respond to a request for an opera from embattled Italian Republicans in Rome. The result was *La*